BIOLOGY 230: ECOLOGY IN YOUR LIFE (EIYL) PROJECT

Updated October 31, 2025

Using observations and/or research collected online or in person, address a specific ecological question. The project should be locally focused (e.g. home, neighbourhood, local park, municipality) or based on recent events/research. You must explicitly make connections to ecological concepts learned in lecture and/or lab and target an undergraduate audience that isn't familiar with our course. Ideally, the project will address a question or topic you are personally interested in. You can request to work in pairs, if desired.

Lab Brainstorming Activity

Attend your lab (Nov. 1-5) to participate in a brainstorming activity to help you think of project ideas. 3 days after the end of your lab session, you will submit a short proposal.

Proposal (1% of grade)

Due: 3 days after your lab proposal session (due dates Nov. 6-10) at 5 pm (buffer to 11:59 pm)

Guidelines: In no more than half a page single-spaced, describe:

(1) The ecological question on which you are basing your project
(2) Where and how you will be making your observations and/or collecting research
(3) Your chosen presentation style (see examples under "Project")

Your proposal will be marked on completeness of the above criteria (not on how "good" your idea is). You will receive feedback about whether your project is feasible/appropriate and if any tweaks need to be made.

If you are really struggling to come up with an idea, you should contact your TA and/or Rachel to bounce some thoughts off them.

Group work: If you are working with a partner, include the name and lab section of your partner in the proposal, as well as a brief explanation of how each of you will contribute. You should each submit the proposal on Canvas, but the proposal text can be the same between you and your partner. If your partner is in a different section, your proposal can be submitted by the later deadline. Groups larger than 2 people are not allowed.

Changing your proposal: Any changes made to your project after your proposal has been submitted will need to be approved by Rachel or your TA.

Office Hours

Before the project is due, TAs will hold drop-in office hours for you to get help with your project (see lab schedule on Canvas). Rachel will continue to have weekly office hours. If you need help outside of those times, you can email Rachel/your TA to schedule a separate appointment, or post on Piazza.

Project (8% of grade)

Due: Friday, December 5, 5:00 pm (buffer to 11:59 pm)

Presentation styles

You will not be penalized if your project is shorter or longer than the suggested lengths – they are just guidelines to ensure your project is appropriately scaled. If your project largely relies on audio (e.g., podcast), please include a transcript to help your TA follow along; this transcript does not have to be word-for-word identical.

- Short video (~10 min)
- Blog or Instagram (9-12 total posts)
- Podcast (audio recording totaling 10-15 min)
- Written paper (2-3 pages single-spaced)
- Pamphlet with infographics (treat more like a scientific poster than a showcase of illustrations)
- Be creative, as long as it comprehensively addresses your ecological question!

Objectives

The grading rubric quantifies your success in meeting each of the following objectives:

- Demonstrates impressive analysis and/or summary of a local/current/important ecological interaction, phenomenon, or issue
- Explicitly contextualizes project concepts with lecture and/or lab concepts to demonstrate broader understanding of ecological topics
- Effectively communicates ideas to a general audience (i.e., an undergrad not familiar with our course)
- Demonstrates interest in the project (through creativity and/or knowledge) and effort
    - Note that effort will be held to a higher standard for projects completed in groups

Group work: If you had a partner, you will both need to submit an additional statement of each partner's contributions to the project.

Works referenced: If you consulted any sources for this project, online or otherwise, please include them in a "Works Referenced" list at the end of your project. You do not need to cite specific statements, though you can do so if you wish. You also do not need to format your citations in any specific way, as long as it's clear what your source was. You can reference the library project guide (https://guides.library.ubc.ca/biol230). See the lab manual for policies pertaining to chatGPT use and make sure you declare any use of AI tools.

Back-Up Plan

Reach out to Rachel and your TA if you're running into trouble with your project. If your project is deemed to be infeasible with no possible workaround, we will arrange a back-up plan for you, which will be a report similar in style to the Pacific Spirit Park report. This is a last resort only and available only in special circumstances, so make sure you put in the time to think of a doable project and get help as needed.